

Here are questions to help you evaluate the deal (relevant whether you are planning a party for a 5-year-old or an 80-year-old):

What is the price and time limit for the room or facility rental?

Can I bring as many guests as I'd like or is there a maximum number?

Will I have space dedicated to my party or will I share the space?

Is there a minimum number of guests (that I need to pay for whether they come to the party or not)?

Are decorations included?

Is food included?

Are treat or goody bags included and, if so, are they filled or empty?

Do you need to bring a birthday cake or is one provided?

Treat bags are optional. You don't have to give treat bags filled with very small, probably useless toys (which I am sure I did at least once). Here are some alternatives:

- A book (give everyone the same title)
- Pencils and candy (parents will like one; kids, the other)
- Deck of cards or other inexpensive but nice-to-have item
- Crayons or markers purchased at back-to-school sales with a coloring book from the dollar store
- Random items given as prizes throughout the party

What I've learned:

1. More kids usually means more fun.
2. Younger children (three to four and younger) may enjoy a very small party that is more of a play-date with cake rather than a big birthday party.
3. Certain activities can be overdone (for example, one of my child's guests attended two bowling parties in one day).
4. If you have to choose, spend money for a cool activity or a place for kids to have plenty of space, rather than decorations.
5. Kids who are usually ravenous don't eat much at parties (I still make sure we have plenty but typically have leftovers).
6. There are a surprising number of children who do not eat cake *and* ice cream.
7. Take pictures to make the day memorable. — **Julie Rains**

